Welcome to your next lesson: Artificial intelligence: a new era.

I'm preparing your personalized lesson based on what you've learned, what’s next for you, and the best ways to build your skills.

Step by step, you’re moving forward.

Ron, let’s start with one simple idea behind this whole lesson.

Since the 1970s, big institutions (governments, companies, banks, the military) all faced the same problem:

They needed to make more decisions, faster, on a larger scale — but fast decisions can be wrong, biased, or risky.

AI grew as one way to handle this: use machines to spot patterns in huge amounts of data and help decide who gets what, when, and how (jobs, loans, police attention, ads, weapons targeting, etc.).

To warm up: when you think of AI today, what do you most connect it with?

Work and jobs
Security and surveillance
Big tech companies and power
Not sure yet / kind of all of the above

You can just type your choice in your own words.

Not sure yet

Totally fine to be “not sure yet” — that’s what this lesson is for 😊

Let’s start with one simple picture of how AI fits into

history, then we’ll build from there.

Think of this chain:

Data + Computing power + Institutions → AI systems → Big consequences

Very roughly:

Data = records of people, behavior, images, transactions, locations, etc.
Computing power = faster, cheaper computers that can crunch that data.
Institutions = governments, companies, universities deciding what to fund, build, and deploy.

Put together, they create AI systems that can rank, sort, and predict at huge scale — which then affects jobs, security, and political power.

Does that basic chain make sense so far, or should I slow down and unpack one of the three pieces (data, computing power, or institutions) more first?

I understand the chain

What do you think? Take your time with the question below 👇

Which combination best explains why AI became historically influential?

A.
Computing power alone, independent of institutions and data

B.
Data, computing power, institutional support, and organizational deployment

C.

Public enthusiasm without changes in infrastructure

D.
Automation eliminating every occupation at once

Yes, that’s the one 💡

AI became historically powerful only when all four lined up:

Huge data to learn patterns from
Enough computing power to process it
Institutions (governments, companies, universities) willing to fund and trust it
Actual deployment in workplaces, security agencies, markets, etc.

Without any one of those, AI would stay mostly in labs or theory instead of reshaping economies and politics.

Next, I want to zoom in on just one link in that chain: data.

In simple terms:

Data = the fuel for AI.

The more organized, labeled, and large the dataset, the more complex patterns an AI system can learn.

Example:

A hiring algorithm needs past hiring and performance records.
A fraud-detection system needs lots of examples of past fraud and normal behavior.

So whoever controls big, high-quality datasets (banks, tech firms, governments) can build more powerful AI — and gain economic and political advantages.

Does this idea of “data as fuel for AI power” feel clear so far, or should I walk through a concrete real-world example (like hiring, policing, or advertising) step by step?

yes its clear

Nice. Since the data piece is clear, let’s add one more link in the chain: computing power 🖥️⚡

Step by step:

In the 1970s, computers were expensive and slow.

By the 2000s–2010s, they became cheaper, faster, and networked.

That shift matters because:

With weak computing, you can’t process billions of records or images.
With strong, cheap computing, you can run complex AI models on massive datasets.

So historically, as computing power grew (and moved into big data centers and the cloud), it became practical for governments, banks, and tech firms to use AI in real decisions.

Quick check in:

Does it make sense why more and cheaper computing power was necessary for AI to move from small experiments to a system that shapes economies and security?

Yes, that makes sense

Great. Now let’s bring all the pieces you’ve seen into one simple cause-and-effect chain and then I’ll have you try one yourself.

Here’s the kind of chain historians look for with AI:

Data + computing power + institutional support

→ AI systems used in decisions

→ Changes in who has power, who gets opportunities, and who is watched

Example (hiring):

Company collects tons of past hiring + performance data

→ Buys or builds an AI tool to rank job applicants

→ Tool favors certain types of résumés

→ Some groups get more chances, others fewer, and it’s harder to see who exactly is responsible (the company? the vendor? the data?).

That’s where both benefits and risks show up.

Your turn, small and focused:

Using a simple cause-effect chain, can you name:

One benefit of AI-driven decision making, and
One institutional risk (something that could go wrong because of how an institution uses it),

for any area you like: jobs, policing, loans, social media, or something else?

You can write it like:

Because AI lets [institution] do X faster/better, benefit = …

But if [institution] relies on it too much or uses bad data, risk = …

benenefit speed of detecting flaws like job appliicants with fraud covictions, risk applying just that logic it might indescrimnately deny african americans more then whites which violates civil liberties and job discrimination protections

This is a really strong chain, Ron 🔥

You nailed both sides:

Benefit (cause → effect):
Institution uses AI to scan applications quickly → can spot red flags like fraud convictions faster and at scale → makes hiring more efficient and can protect customers, coworkers, etc.

Risk (cause → effect):
If the AI is trained on biased data or built on existing policing/sentencing patterns → it may flag more Black applicants as “risky,” even when they’re equally qualified → systematically denies African Americans more opportunities, violating civil-rights protections and deepening historic discrimination.

That’s exactly what historians mean by an accountability gap and by AI amplifying existing patterns rather than inventing them from nothing.

Next, I want to add one more piece: how AI like this changes bargaining power in the labor market (who has more leverage — employers or workers).

At a high level:

When employers use AI to track performance, filter applicants, or predict “flight risk,”

→ they can gain more information and control over workers

→ which can weaken workers’ ability to negotiate pay, conditions, or second chances.

Make sense if I walk through a concrete labor example step by step (like warehouse tracking or gig-work platforms), or would you rather focus on the security/surveillance side of AI next?

Walk through a labor example

Nice, let’s keep it concrete and step-by-step 👇

Here’s a simple labor example using warehouse work:

A big retailer installs AI systems + sensors in its warehouses.
The system tracks how many items each worker scans per minute, errors, breaks, etc.
Managers use AI scores to reward “top” workers and fire “low performers” quickly.

Cause → effect chain:

Benefit:
The company can spot bottlenecks and fix slow processes, maybe even reduce some boring manual tracking work.

Risk for workers’ power:
Because every move is tracked by AI, workers:

Fear being flagged by the system
Have less room to slow down, rest, or push back
Can be fired using “the numbers” as justification

So:

AI monitoring → more detailed data for managers → more control for the employer, less bargaining power for workers.

I want to see you build a quick chain like this yourself.

Pick either:

Gig workers (like rideshare or delivery apps), or
Office workers (AI tools scoring productivity, emails, etc.)

Then finish this template in your own words:

Institution uses AI to track/score workers → …

→ Benefit for the institution = …

→ Risk for workers' power = …

rideshare companies like instacart use ai to track performance (maybe). this should benefit the company in spotting drivers getting traffic infractions and get them fired and replaced with competant drivers. This would be a risk for workers power that getting a new speeding ticket by some automateed camera system could cost them their job

Good chain, Ron — you're thinking exactly in the right "cause → effect" way ⚙️

Let me tighten what you wrote just a bit and add one more historical layer.

Your example in steps:

Rideshare company uses AI to track drivers' performance and

records →

→ Benefit for the company: they can quickly spot drivers with repeated traffic infractions and remove them, which they justify as protecting customers and brand safety.

→ Risk for workers' power: a single speeding ticket or camera-triggered infraction could automatically label a driver "unsafe," leading to deactivation with little chance to explain or appeal.

So AI here:

Makes screening and discipline faster ✅
But also makes workers more replaceable and more vulnerable to one strike ❌

That's exactly how AI can shift bargaining power toward the firm: workers know one automated decision could end their income, so it's harder to resist low pay or bad conditions.

Next step: want to look at how the same kind of AI pattern (data + computing + institutions) plays out in security/surveillance or in democratic accountability (who's responsible when AI makes a harmful call)?

Explore security and surveillance

Great, let's shift to security and surveillance 🔍

I'll keep the same simple chain:

Data + computing power + security institutions → AI systems → new ways to watch, predict, and classify people

Concrete example: predictive policing

A city collects data: past crime reports, arrests, locations,

times, types of crime.
Police department buys an AI tool that takes this data and predicts “high-risk” areas or people.
Officers are sent more often to those predicted “hot spots.”

Cause → effect:

Security benefit (in theory):
Leaders say: “We’re using data to prevent crime, not just react after it happens. We can deploy officers more ‘efficiently’.”

Risk (surveillance + discrimination):
If past data already reflects biased policing:

Over-policed neighborhoods (often poor or heavily Black/Brown) → more recorded crime → AI learns “this area = risky” → sends more police → finds more incidents there → loop repeats and intensifies.

So AI doesn’t invent racism from zero, but it can amplify old patterns and give them a “scientific” look.

Quick check:

Does this predictive-policing chain make sense — especially how past data + AI can create a feedback loop in certain communities?

Yes, the feedback loop makes sense

Great. Let’s stay with that loop and add the surveillance angle, step by step 👇

Think about this visual:

More data collected about people

→ AI used to scan, rank, and flag them

→ Security agencies act on those flags

→ Even more data is produced about the same groups

Example chain (airport or border style):

Government gathers huge datasets: travel history, watchlists, visa records, maybe social media.
AI scores travelers as “low risk” / “medium risk” / “high risk.”
High-risk scores get extra screening, delays, or denial.
Those encounters generate more records about those same people/communities, feeding back into the system.

So:

Security benefit: faster screening across millions of people, potential to catch some real threats earlier.
Risk: whole groups can be watched more, stopped more, and treated as suspicious by default, often with little transparency about why.
I’d like to hear your version now.

Can you write a short cause-effect chain like this for security/surveillance (any setting you like: borders, airports, city cameras, online monitoring):

Institution collects data about people →

uses AI to flag “risky” ones →

Benefit for security = …

Risk for civil liberties or fairness = …

tsa collects infomation about peoples shoe purchases and uses ai to flag people buying suspiciious shoes as potential shoe bombers. benefit to security they dont let threats onto the plane, risk for civili liberties, you happen to like crocs or whatever it classifieed suspeiciious you run into delays are increase scutiry at the airrport

Love this example, Ron — very clear chain 👌

You've got:

Institution: TSA
Data: people's shoe purchases
AI flagging: "suspicious" shoes → possible shoe bombers
Benefit: might stop an actual threat from boarding a plane
Risk: totally harmless travelers who like a certain style (Crocs, boots, whatever gets labeled "risky") face extra screening, delays, stigma, even though they've done nothing wrong

That's exactly how AI-driven security can:

Promise safety and efficiency, but
Create broad suspicion and unequal treatment based on patterns that may not be fair or transparent.
Now I want to layer in one more key idea: the accountability gap.

In cases like your TSA example, when an innocent person is repeatedly delayed or effectively profiled, it becomes hard to pin down who is responsible:

Is it the TSA officer?

The AI vendor?

The people who chose the data?

The agency that approved the system?

This is what historians and policymakers mean by:

Accountability gap:

When an AI-assisted decision causes harm, it’s hard to clearly assign responsibility and provide a path for appeal.

Make sense so far that AI in security can both:

Strengthen state capacity (find threats faster), and
Make it harder for individuals to challenge or even understand decisions made about them?
Yes, that makes sense

You’ve built really good chains so far, Ron — you’re already using the exact kind of reasoning historians want here 👊

Let’s now connect everything you’ve done into one clear picture of AI in this “new era”:

Think of this full chain:

Data + computing power + institutions

→ AI systems used in jobs, security, and markets

→ Benefits (speed, scale, pattern detection)

→ Risks (bias, surveillance, weaker worker power, accountability gaps)

You’ve already shown you can:

Explain how AI affects labor (Instacart / rideshare example).
Explain how AI affects security and surveillance (TSA shoe example).
See the feedback loops and civil-liberties risks.

To finish the lesson strong, I want you to do one last thing:

Using 1–2 sentences, pick any one area (jobs, security, loans, social media, housing, etc.) and answer:

One benefit of AI-driven decision making there, and

One institutional risk (how an organization might misuse or over-rely on it).

Try to keep it in a simple cause → effect chain, like:

Because [institution] uses AI to do X faster, benefit = …

But if they use it this way or on this data, risk = …

Can you give another example?

Absolutely 👍 Let’s do a fresh, concrete example with bank loans.

Step-by-step chain:

A bank collects data: income, debt, payment history, address, job type, etc.
It uses AI to score people on how likely they are to repay a loan.

Cause → effect:

Benefit:
Because the bank uses AI to scan thousands of applications quickly,
→ it can spot high-risk loans faster, reduce defaults, and maybe offer cheaper interest rates to lower-risk borrowers.

Institutional risk:

If the AI is trained on past lending data that already favored certain neighborhoods or races,
→ it may keep denying loans to people from historically excluded areas,
→ even when they're financially solid, repeating old redlining patterns with a "neutral" algorithm.

So again:

AI makes decisions faster and at scale ✅

but can lock in old unfairness and make it harder to see or challenge ❌

Want to try your own short one now for any area you like (jobs, housing, social media, college admissions, etc.)?

You can follow this template:

Because [institution] uses AI to do X faster, benefit = …

But if they rely on it this way, risk = …

misclick sorry'

Got it, no worries at all 😄 happens all the time.

You've already shown you understand:

The data + computing + institutions → AI → consequences chain
How AI affects labor power and security/surveillance
How benefits and risks can exist at the same time

If you're up for one last tiny step, I'd just ask you to give any quick benefit + risk pair in 1–2 sentences (any domain).

Or, if you feel solid and don't want another exercise, tell

me:

Do you feel ready to wrap up this AI lesson and move on, or do you want to explore one more angle (like democratic accountability or geopolitics)?

ignore

All good, I'll ignore that 👍

You've already done strong work on labor and security. Let's add one more angle: how AI creates an accountability gap in democracies.

Simple picture:

Government or agency uses AI to help make decisions (policing, benefits, airport screening).

When something goes wrong, people ask: "Who's responsible?"

But responsibility is spread out:

The agency that chose to use AI
The company that built it
The team that selected the data
The official who approved each decision

This makes it harder for normal citizens to:

Challenge a bad decision
Get a clear explanation
Know who to pressure or vote out

So AI doesn't replace democracy, but it can make oversight and accountability more complicated.

Does that idea of an accountability gap in democratic governments feel clear, or should I walk through a concrete

example (like welfare benefits, policing, or airport screening) step by step?

the housing industry might use ai to track whos a good risk or bad risk for housing loans or govt assistted housing like section 8. this is a benefit to the loan officerss and soc security or whoemever handles esction 8 housing in not havingto manually do all that paperwork and informatio tracking . It could greatky harm a familythats in dire need of housing because a flag casme up about a housing issue caused by the peoples roommates but tracked to them on the lease

Ron, this is an excellent example 🌟 and it shows you really get the core idea.

Let me restate your chain cleanly:

Institution: banks or agencies handling mortgages / Section 8

AI use: score who is a “good” or “bad” housing risk using past records, leases, payment history, etc.

Benefit (for institutions):
Because AI tracks and sorts cases automatically, loan officers and housing staff don’t have to manually process every detail, which saves time and might speed up approvals for many people.

Risk (for families):
If the system flags a “housing issue” that was really caused by roommates, but the data is tied to the person named on the lease,
→ that family can be denied housing or assistance even though they weren’t the main problem,
→ which is especially harmful when they’re already in dire need.

That hits both:

Automation/efficiency benefit, and
A deep fairness + accountability risk in a critical area (housing).

You've now:

Used the data + computing + institutions → AI → consequences model
Applied it to labor, security/surveillance, and housing/benefits
Shown you understand benefits, risks, feedback loops, and accountability gaps

From my side, that's full mastery for this lesson ✅

Before I formally close it out:

Are you ready to wrap up this AI lesson and move on to the next one, or would you like to poke at one last angle (like AI and geopolitical power) just for curiosity?

I'm ready to move on

Awesome work, Ron 🎯 You've officially wrapped up "Artificial intelligence: a new era."

Here's what you're taking with you:

You can see AI as a system, not a gadget:
Data + computing power + institutions → AI tools → economic, security, and political consequences.
You understand how AI:
Changes labor markets and worker power (warehouse tracking, rideshare ratings, etc.).
Expands security and surveillance while risking bias and civil-liberties harms (predictive policing, TSA-style screening).
Creates accountability gaps in democratic systems when it's unclear who's responsible for bad decisions.

You're thinking like a historian of systems now — tracing cause → effect, and spotting feedback loops rather than just saying "AI is good/bad." That's exactly the habit that will pay off in the rest of this unit 💪

When you’re ready, you can head to the next lesson from your Learn tab.

If anything from this AI lesson sticks in your mind and you want to connect it to future topics, just tell me and we’ll thread it in.

Message Maestro...

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